Reading Comprehension

Grade 4 | Read each passage, then answer the five questions on the next page.

The Library of Seeds

On the first Saturday of spring, Mina found a wooden cabinet beside the community garden gate. Its shelves held small paper envelopes, each labeled with a plant name and a year. A sign read: TAKE A FEW SEEDS. GROW THEM. RETURN SOME WHEN YOU CAN.

Mr. Alvarez, who tended the garden, explained that the cabinet was a seed library. People shared seeds from flowers and vegetables they had grown. Mina chose a packet of purple bean seeds. Her grandmother had grown beans like those in the backyard of the apartment where she once lived, but Mina had never planted anything taller than a windowsill herb.

At home, Mina and her grandmother pushed the seeds into a pot of dark soil. Mina watered it every morning. For a week, nothing happened. She began to think the seeds were empty. Her grandmother asked her to wait and showed her how to check the soil: damp, not soggy. On the ninth day, a green hook broke through the surface.

The bean plant climbed a string tied to the balcony rail. Each day Mina measured it with a ruler and marked the height on a chart. When a windy afternoon bent the stem, she added a second string for support. By midsummer, the plant had white blossoms and long pods. Mina saved several dry beans in a new envelope and wrote the date on it.

In autumn, she returned to the cabinet. Mr. Alvarez placed her envelope beside older packets. Mina noticed that one envelope had traveled through many hands: its label listed three gardens and four years. She slid her own seeds onto the shelf. They were not just beans now, she thought. They were a small promise that someone else could grow something, too.

Questions: The Library of Seeds

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use details from the passage when asked.

1. What is the main idea of the passage? Use two details to explain how Mina learns what a seed library makes possible.

2. Why does Mina begin to doubt the seeds, and what changes her mind? Support your answer with details from the passage.

3. What can you infer about Mina and her grandmother from the way they care for the bean plant? Give evidence for your inference.

4. In the final paragraph, what does the word "promise" suggest about Mina's seeds? Explain using the passage.

5. How does the detail about the envelope that traveled through three gardens and four years help develop the passage's message?

A Map Made of Sound

Noor and her uncle waited quietly at the edge of the orchard as the sky darkened. They were counting bats for a neighborhood science project. Noor held a small recorder that could pick up sounds too high for most people to hear. Her uncle reminded her not to shine a bright light toward the trees.

Soon, tiny clicks crackled through the headphones. A bat sends out high-pitched calls and listens for the echoes that bounce back from nearby objects. The returning sounds help it locate insects and avoid branches, even in darkness. Noor could not see the calls, but the recorder changed them into lower sounds she could hear.

At first, Noor wrote down every burst as one bat. Then her uncle pointed to the screen. Some calls were spaced far apart; others came in quick clusters. A single bat might change its calling pattern as it chased an insect, he explained, so the number of clicks did not always tell them how many bats were flying.

Noor looked up from the screen. One bat swooped near the apple trees, then turned sharply toward the pond. The calls grew faster just before the turn. She added a note to her chart: 'Quick calls, then left toward water.' She did not claim to know exactly what the bat had heard. Instead, she recorded what she could observe and marked the rest as a question.

The next morning, Noor compared her notes with recordings from other nights. The bats often made more calls near the orchard than over the open field. Her uncle said the trees might offer both insects to eat and places to shelter. Noor added that idea to the project as a possibility, not a proven fact. Her map had no drawn roads, but it showed how careful listening could reveal a hidden route.

Questions: A Map Made of Sound

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use details from the passage when asked.

1. Explain how a bat uses sound to find its way. Which details show that its calls do more than make noise?

2. Why does Noor stop counting each burst of calls as a separate bat? Use evidence from the passage.

3. What does Noor's note-taking reveal about how she approaches scientific observations? Support your answer with two details.

4. In the last paragraph, what does "possibility, not a proven fact" mean? Explain why Noor treats the orchard idea this way.

5. What is the main idea of the passage? Explain how Noor's recording and her observations help develop it.

The Net on the Hill

In the dry coastal town where Pía lived, clouds sometimes drifted over the hills without dropping rain. Her science class visited a hillside fog collector: a tall net stretched between two wooden posts. Pía expected the net to catch fog like a blanket catches dust. Instead, it turned fog into drinking water.

Tiny droplets in the moving air struck the net and joined together. When the drops grew heavy, they slid down into a narrow gutter and flowed through a pipe to a covered barrel. The collector did not make water from nothing; it gathered moisture already carried by the fog. The class measured the barrel and wrote down how much water had collected overnight.

Pía noticed that a loose corner of the net flapped in the wind. The next morning, the barrel held less water than the class had expected. Her classmate Tomás thought the fog had been thinner. Pía checked the weather notes: the fog had lasted nearly as long as the night before. She wondered if the loose net had let some droplets blow past.

The class tightened the corner and placed a second measuring cup beneath a different part of the gutter. On the next foggy night, the collector gathered more water. That did not prove the loose corner had caused all the difference, because the wind and fog could change from night to night. But the test gave the class a useful clue, and they planned to measure for several more evenings.

Pía drew a diagram for the school display. She showed the net, gutter, pipe, and barrel, then added arrows for the fog moving uphill. Beside the drawing she wrote: 'A good idea needs careful testing.' The collector would not solve every water shortage, but it could help the town save some water on misty days. Pía liked that the class had improved a real tool by asking a small question and checking what happened.

Questions: The Net on the Hill

Answer each question in complete sentences. Use details from the passage when asked.

1. Describe how the fog collector gathers water. Include the path the droplets follow from the air to the barrel.

2. Why does Pía question the idea that thinner fog caused the lower water amount? Use details from the passage.

3. What can you infer about why the class made more than one measurement? Support your answer with evidence.

4. What does the phrase "a useful clue" mean in this passage? Explain what the class learned and what it still did not know.

5. What is the main idea of the passage? Explain how the class's test supports that idea.